

Retaining a Forensic Engineering Expert

A 10-point checklist for attorneys and claims professionals · by Eric Trillas, P.E.

Before the engagement

- Confirm who will personally inspect the evidence, develop the opinions, and testify — and whether it is the same engineer.
- Ask how the engineer distinguishes an investigation from an opinion — the opinion should follow the evidence, never precede it.
- Verify licensure in the state where the matter sits, and board certifications relevant to the issues (P.E., S.I., or equivalent).
- Ask for examples of how complex findings were explained to non-engineers — judges, jurors, adjusters.

Scoping the work

- Define the technical question in one sentence before requesting a proposal.
- Ask what information is needed initially — and what is not necessary yet. Focused investigations cost less and hold up better.
- Retain early enough to evaluate physical evidence before repairs, alterations, or loss of access.
- Confirm the engineer works with accredited laboratories and field-testing entities when testing is warranted.

Evaluating the opinion

- A credible report distinguishes what the evidence supports, what it does not, and what cannot be determined.
- Confirm the engineer is comfortable identifying the limitations of the evidence — stated uncertainty is a strength under cross, not a weakness.

Have a matter that may require an engineering expert? TCE responds within one business day — usually the same afternoon. Read the full article:

trillasengineering.com/questions-to-ask-forensic-engineering-expert.html

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